

Apple hits pause on AI in its boldest move yet

It's been close to a month since Apple launched its new set of iPhones. The hype has settled and the products are in the real world for first-hand feedback. I have been using the iPhone 17 Pro Max for almost a week as well. But, I am not going to talk about it yet. I want to actually comment on Apple's obvious and most interesting move — the decision to hit pause of its AI efforts or Apple Intelligence. When I was at the Apple Park last year for the iPhone 16 series launch, there was so much excitement around Apple Intelligence, indicating that AI will define the next few years for the Cupertino tech company. A year later, there was barely any mention of it in Apple's keynote. I think it's for the good.

For much of the past decade, Apple's iPhone launches have followed a predictable rhythm. A faster processor here, a slightly sharper camera there and the occasional new finish to keep things interesting. Incrementalism became the norm, even as competitors like Samsung, Google and a surging Chinese smartphone industry pushed the boundaries of what a smartphone could do. Apple, it seemed, had fallen back on its reputation rather than reinventing it.

The iPhone 17 series though might serve as a deliberate strategic pivot for Apple as it has gone back to basics — prioritising hardware, materials and engineering over flashy but half-baked software promises. Apple's missteps in AI weren't just a matter of hype gone wrong. It was rare moment was Apple was actually chasing and not leading. And after a year where its much-hyped Apple Intelligence features underdelivered, this recalibration feels like a much-needed course correction.

Even before using the iPhone 17 Pro Max, I could see the change in approach. Starting with the color: who saw Apple debut an Orange color on its most expensive phone? Well, not me. And, it has been received so weak. Apple has also returned return to sturdier, cooler-to-the-touch materials that make



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the phone feel reliable again. Subtle changes to weight distribution and curvature give the devices a fresher silhouette, a reminder that tactile experience still counts.

The upgrades aren't just cosmetic. The Pro Max now offers improved battery endurance, addressing one of the most consistent complaints of recent years. The addition of an 8x telephoto zoom finally closes the gap with competitors who have long offered superior optical range.

The early sales figures tell their own story. Apple's hardware-first pivot appears to be resonating. There were queue lines at Apple Stores, sales data shows that Pro models have driven bulk of purchases and the Orange color seems to be most in demand. This response will be a relief for Apple's leadership. For much of the past year, analysts have warned of stagnation in the premium smartphone category. Consumers were holding onto devices longer, waiting for a reason to upgrade. The iPhone 17 series, by focusing on the tangible rather than the theoretical, has finally provided one.

So, has Apple quietly withdrawn from the AI race? It's difficult to say. But, one thing is clear that instead of sprinting ahead with features that lack polish, Apple seems content to run a marathon. By allowing rivals to set expectations, the company can bide its time, entering the fray only when it believes it can redefine the category.

There's risk in this approach. If AI truly becomes the defining layer of smartphone value, Apple could find itself years behind. But the company has weathered similar doubts before, if you recollect.

The real test, I think, will come in 2026, when Apple is expected to reboot and relaunch its AI ambitions. By then, Siri may finally feel like the assistant it was always meant to be. Until then, the iPhone 17 proves that sometimes, innovation isn't about flashy features — it's about getting the basics right, and making them feel magical again. **d**